Bannaa in plain words

A simple guide to what Bannaa is and how it works · Version of 18 October 2026

In one sentence: Bannaa (بنّاء) is a computer app that helps you put your phone down, by locking distracting apps in a way you can't undo from the phone in a weak moment.

The problem

Most screen-time apps live on the phone itself. When the urge to scroll wins, you can switch them off, delete them or find a way around them in seconds. Willpower alone isn't enough when the "off" switch is in your hand.

What Bannaa does

Bannaa moves the "off" switch to your computer. You connect your phone to your computer with a cable once. From then on, your computer is the only thing that can loosen the rules, and your phone enforces the blocks by itself, even with no internet and the computer switched off.

- It blocks the apps and websites you choose, such as social media, short videos, games and news.
- It can't be deleted from the phone, and the phone can't be reset from its settings to get around it.
- It is designed in Arabic first, with a full English version.
- It works on Android phones first, with iPhone following.

What you need

- A Mac or Windows computer.
- Your phone and its USB cable, for a one-time setup.
- About 15 minutes.

Setting it up

1. **Install Bannaa on your computer** and connect your phone with the cable.
2. **Follow the step-by-step guide.** It tells you exactly what to tap on your phone and checks each step as you go.
3. **A few temporary steps:** on Android you briefly remove your Google account (and the phone maker's account, if you have one) from the phone, then add it back. On iPhone you briefly turn off "Find My", then turn it back on. Your photos, apps and data stay where they are.
4. **On iPhone,** you also install the small Bannaa helper app from the App Store by scanning a code shown on your computer.
5. **Choose what to block** and pick how strict you want Bannaa to be (see "Normal or strict" below).

6. **Write down your 24 recovery words** and keep them somewhere safe. You'll need them if you ever lose your computer.

Three ways to block

Type	How it starts	How it ends
Manual block	One tap, on the computer or the phone	Only from your computer, after a short waiting time
Focus session	Pick 25, 50 or 90 minutes, or your own time	Only when the time runs out. It can't be stopped early
Schedule	Set it once, for example every night from 10 pm to 7 am	At the end of the window. It can't be lifted while it's running

Why you can't just switch it off

- **Only your computer can loosen the rules.** The phone can always make things stricter, but never looser.
- **Loosening always waits.** Allowing an app or changing a schedule only happens after a waiting time you choose, from no wait at all up to 7 days (10 minutes by default). By the time it takes effect, the urge has usually passed.
- **Nothing loosens during a block.** If you ask to loosen something during a focus session or schedule, Bannaa holds the request until the block ends.
- **Turning the phone off doesn't help.** A restart, a flat battery or changing the clock never ends a block early.

Normal or strict

During setup you choose how strict Bannaa should be:

- **Normal (recommended to start):** you can loosen rules from your computer, after the waiting time.
- **Strict:** a commitment with no end date. Nothing can be loosened while it's on. When you want out, you ask from your computer, and a countdown of 7, 30 or 90 days (picked at setup) starts. Everything stays strict until it ends, then Bannaa goes back to normal.

Explicit content filter

Bannaa also blocks adult websites, all day, every day, separately from your other blocks. It also forces safe search on Google, Bing and DuckDuckGo, in every browser, so explicit results don't show up. It is switched on at setup and stays on. It can't be turned off, from the phone or the computer.

Always available

Some things are never blocked, so a block can never leave you stranded: phone calls, emergency calls, text messages, maps, banking apps and sign-in code apps.

If you lose your computer

Your 24 recovery words let you take control again from a new computer, without resetting your phone. You can do this twice. After that, or if you also lose the words, Bannaa's team can send you a one-time code that works only for your phone. Your rules carry over unchanged, and nothing can be loosened for 24 hours after a recovery, so recovery can't be used as a shortcut around a block.

Your privacy

Bannaa has no accounts and no servers. Your rules, schedules and statistics stay on your computer and your phone. Nothing is sent anywhere.

Stopping Bannaa

You're always free to stop using Bannaa, for example when you sell or change your phone. You remove it from your computer with "Retire phone". This is refused during any block or while strict mode is on, and it waits at least 24 hours (or your waiting time, if that's longer), so a sudden urge to quit has time to pass.

Honest limits

- Anyone who fully erases their phone using another computer can remove Bannaa. That's possible with every product of this kind. The cost is losing everything on the phone, which is far more than a distraction is worth.
- On some iPhones, setup may need the phone to be erased and restored from a backup. Bannaa tries the gentler ways first.

The first version and what comes later

In the first version: one phone and one computer, manual blocks, focus sessions, weekly schedules, normal and strict modes, the explicit content filter, simple statistics (hours blocked, sessions completed, streaks), and recovery with the 24 words.

Planned for later: prayer-time and Ramadan schedules, a mode for parents, more than one phone per computer, iPad, an option where a trusted friend holds the key to loosen your rules, and stronger content filtering, such as blocking explicit searches.

Still being decided: whether Bannaa will be free or paid.